How Ghosts Serve Man



Though Richard Wagner focused his opera, The Flying Dutchman, on the drama taking place on land, there was much of interest that involved the cursed ship captain and his ghostly crew while on the sea. On one occasion, the ship picks up a priest who was bobbing in the ocean, tossed overboard by a passenger ship whose sailors had gotten weary of his constant preaching. The man of the cloth, well versed in the ways of Satan, is unperturbed by the spectral auras surrounding his saviors. What should have worried him, however, was the fact that these sailors in their previous lives had been cannibals, and though ghosts don't eat, they never really lose the urge. They argue amongst themselves about the best way to prepare a priest, but they seem hopelessly deadlocked -- there are just too many potential cooks. Some argue for roasting the padre, others for marinating him in orange marmalade, and so forth. The captain is incensed. "You can't eat him," he cries. "He's our guest!" Hearing this, the ghost crew resolves to mutiny, and having reached this consensus, they surprisingly find themselves also in agreement concerning how to cook the priest. Their conclusion: Mutiny spooks broil the cloth.